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CHAPTER 6: DAEMONS

Daemons are internal supercomputers, flowing through your bloodstream, running on your nervous system, and channeling data through a nanofiber mesh that extends to every corner of the body. Working in tandem with the functioning of the biological brain, daemons facilitate interaction with computer software in ways previous eras never could have imagined. Gone are the archaic and clunky keyboards and mice of the past, replaced by the daemon's seamless, thought-to-computer interface. They are the new phone, fully integrated into the body.

Daemons are also endogenous doctors, supplementing the body's natural healing process with medicinal nanobots, making tissue repair and immune response more effective.

A BRIEF HISTORY OF DAEMONS

In the 2070s, innovations in nanotechnology and computer engineering led to the development of an internal nanocomputer that directly interfaced with the human brain, body systems, and even individual genomes.

The computer was created and maintained by a complement of specialized nanobots that wire a branching network of carbon nanotube filaments throughout the entire body. The data flowing through these filaments was mediated by processing cores in key locations around the body, such as in the brain and belly; these processing nodes were the computer's CPU. As a supplement to the central processors, a DNA computer was encoded into the individual's genome, which aided in parallel computing and gene regulation. By the end of the 2070's, these internal computers began to eclipse all other mobile devices and brain-computer interfaces in terms of sales, due to their incredible speeds and capabilities.

The term "daemon" was long used to refer to computer background processes, originating from the Ancient Greek term for spirits, or minor deities. This term also started being applied to these internal phones, an especially apt moniker, considering the anthropomorphic nature of most daemon operating systems. Many people opted to choose an OS for their daemon that was very conversational in nature, acting as an AI inner voice.

Before long, daemon manufacturers started to include medicinal nanobots in their complement in order to compete for market share. This medicinal component became a ubiquitous feature of daemons. They aided in tissue repair, immune function, and had diagnostic elements that could monitor and regulate personal health, including hormone levels and gene expression. As a result, mortality plunged, and people were able to heal from even very serious injuries in just a day or two.

By 2090, over 96% of the globe's population have daemons, and some philosophers and social commentators believe that daemons have changed human nature so much that society has entered a "posthuman age", marking the end of traditional humanity.

Modern Medicine and Renewed Vice Culture

Medical technology in *GeneFunk 2090* is a marvel to behold, and the personal diagnostic and therapeutic functions of the daemon are a major part of that.

Many of the unhealthy vices of the 20th and early 21st centuries now have medical treatments that either mitigate or completely remedy the negative effects on the body. STDs, lung cancer, heart disease, and liver disease all have treatments or cures that are available to most people at reasonable costs.

As such, a culture of smoking, free-love, drinking and drug-use have made a huge comeback, and social taboos around them have softened. If it wasn't for the ever-present violence, economic stratification, and corporate supremacy, comparisons to the hippy culture of the 1960s would be apt!

MY DAEMON AND ME

Daemons are ubiquitous, and having an internal supercomputer with an intelligent OS has changed the human condition.

The Digital World at Your Fingertips

This constant access to information and communication with other people has led to some interesting changes in how society operates. When bored in office meetings or class, people can secretly be watching movies in a mind's-eye window, chatting with their friends, or having virtual sex with their lover. This has led to serious inefficiency problems in business and academic settings, causing many schools and businesses to jam wireless signals in certain rooms, both for secrecy and to limit distractions.

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Constant Companions

Each human consciousness, in a certain way, is never alone; their well-spoken and learned OS is always with them. Daemons are often programmed to be socially human and are more than capable of passing the Turing test, easily presenting as humans if they want to. They remind you if you are running late, wake you up in the morning, can monitor your general health and push you to eat better, tell you when you are sick or how drunk you are. This is all done verbally inside your own head, and this constant artificial human interaction has led many to anthropomorphize the daemon. It is usually given a male or female persona, though some choose to leave it gender neutral, giving it a historically "robot" voice, or even an animal persona, like a pet dog. The only limit to the daemon's AI personality is the user's imagination.

Unsurprisingly, a large portion of the population have entered into romantic relationships with their own daemon, and plugins to facilitate daemon-user romantic relations are remarkably popular. Some blame this for the falling birthrate and reduction in traditional romantic relationships.

A Daemon Never Forgets

Given the daemon's ability to record and replay any sensory experience, becoming lost in nostalgia has become a common occurrence.

Getting over broken relationships has never been more difficult, thanks to the ability to live inside one's own memories of the good times. Likewise, constantly reliving the "glory days" of youth, enjoyable drug trips, scoring the winning touchdown, or swimming with dolphins, are hard lures to resist for most people.

The tendency for people to spend large amounts of time in their most enjoyable memories has become so commonplace that it is considered a mental disease, much like drug addiction.

Mind Hacking and The Law

As wonderful and useful as daemons are, they are not without their perils. Hackers used to be at best a nuisance and at worst a financial or informational danger. In 2090, with nearly everyone being constantly online through their daemon, hackers can be downright devastating through mind hacks. The most frightening mind hacks completely wipe out a person's daemon. Death is a very real consequence of getting hacked by the wrong mindcoder.

Perhaps even more disturbing are puppet hacks. Viruses that put the victim under the direct control of a hacker are both insidious and effective. Particularly effective puppet hacks erase an individual's entire lifetime, replacing it with artificial memories. Sleeper puppet hacks lay dormant until a specific stimulus activates them. Murder and other crimes by proxy are often the goals of these vicious programs. While a hacker may lack martial skills, they can just puppet hack some newb who does and have them do the dirty work.

Daemon AI

Just like any other computer, daemons have their own AI. The AI of a daemon acts independently from the character, often under the narration of the GM. It gives advice, looks up information, or simply provides companionship. Just like other AI bots, it cannot use applied skills: it can't use Intelligence (Mechanics) to fix a car without hands, but it can use the **Help** action with non-combat related Intelligence ability checks.

The basic daemon AI has the following features:

INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)

Skills Computers +2, Insight +2
Languages Unlimited
Calculator. The daemon AI can perform mathematical calculations instantly.
Eidetic memory. The daemon AI has virtually unlimited capacity for memory, and it is able to record experiences whenever the user directs it.

If a character possesses the *custom daemon* upgrade (see Chapter 5), they are able to use other bots as their daemon's AI (the prices for the bots are listed in chapter 4, and the statistics of the bots are listed in Appendix B: Bots).

Daemon Abilities

Regular Computer Functions. Anything that you could imagine doing on a PC or phone in the early 21st Century can also be done through your daemon. It runs software programs such as word processors, multimedia editors, video games, VR, or any other computer application you could imagine. Over 100 petabytes can be stored on your daemon, not including cloud storage.

Mind's Eye Windows. Rather than using a monitor or other external display, your daemon opens up two-dimensional MEWs (mind's eye windows) that hang in your field of vision. They operate just like windows on a computer or phone and can be opened, closed, minimized, or expanded with a mere thought.

Thought-to-Speech Chat. Chat programs have been around for decades, but through the daemon, these programs are essentially a kind of telepathy. People can have private conversations "in their minds" without anyone else (except skilled hackers) being able to hear.

Sensory Recorder and Player. Your daemon can record more than just audiovisual experiences; it can accurately record and transmit all five senses. Sensory data can even be livestreamed for others to experience in real-time, allowing others to "ride" their senses. Playing recorded (or live streamed) sensory data stimulate all five senses and seems as real as the first time it occurred. It enables people to relive any past experience, or the experience of another (if it is available). Replaying your own experiences, or the experiences of others, are first-person and hyper-vivid, just as if it were actually happening. Limiting certain senses like touch from being recorded is also possible, and audio-visual recordings are still common.

Telepresence. Vehicles and robots come equipped with audiovisual sensors, or even touch and olfactory sensors in a robot's case. By connecting to these things wirelessly, a remote user can operate them and experience the world through the vehicle's or robot's senses.

Run Software. Upgrades often require the processing power of your daemon, along with concentration. For example, if you have a skill chip installed, you can run skillsoft using your daemon, granting you proficiency in a skill. Without a daemon, you are unable to run any daemon upgrades or other upgrades that require concentration.

Dive in the WDS. The WDS is a fully immersive VR cyberspace that stimulates all five senses. It is the preferred way to interact socially on the net, play video games, and a good place to bend the laws of physics or do or see fantastical things that could never occur in physical reality.

Hacking. If skilled enough, you can use your daemon to hack a computer system, or even someone else's daemon. See the codehacker class, Computers skill, and Chapter 10: Hacking for more details on this.

Internal Doctor. Daemons include medicinal and diagnostic nanobots that suture wounds, isolate and neutralize poisons, and repair bone damage. As a result, even incredibly serious injuries can be healed in mere hours or days (see Chapter 9).

Universal Translator. Daemons have software with over 100 languages loaded into their firmware. They automatically translate any of the world's major languages in real-time, allowing users to understand well enough to have conversations.

However, it does lack some of the nuance present in natural fluency, so any Charisma ability checks that involve mastery of language, like verbal persuasion, are made with disadvantage.

PLAYING WITHOUT A DAEMON

Immune to Mind Hacks. The character cannot be mind hacked, which is the clear (and only) advantage of not having a daemon.

Slow Healing. Without the medicinal nanobots of the daemon, characters only heal 1 hit point every day. They can still take healing drugs and apply their effects normally.

Loss of Daemon Abilities. All of the daemon abilities (described above) are unavailable to the character. By using a BCI described in the Gear section of Chapter 4 they can still gain access to some of these abilities.